

Social Displacement in a Renovating Neighborhood's Commercial District: Atlanta

Michael Chernoff

This is a case study of a neighborhood commercial district, Little Five Points (LFP) in Atlanta, which has changed in composition over the past several years. Any city area changes over time, but here the new arrivals share characteristics which distinguish them from the older business people. The newcomers are demographically different and hold different philosophies toward their businesses, and the commercial district as a whole, than do the older merchants. This compositional change and the tension it produces will be discussed within the framework of social displacement, in contrast to physical displacement.

By social displacement I mean the replacement of one group by another, in some relatively bounded geographic area, in terms of prestige and power. This includes the ability to affect decisions and policies in the area, to set goals and priorities, and to be recognized by outsiders as the legitimate spokesmen for the area. Social displacement is then a typical accompanying feature of physical displacement. Yet physical displacement need not always go along with social displacement. In the case considered here, the older group of business people has not been displaced physically, but they have lost a considerable amount of the neighborhood control they once had. This idea provides a guide to understanding

the conflict which has arisen in Little Five Points and which may be inevitable in any changing residential or business neighborhood.

Social displacement can manifest itself in several ways. For example, the loss of political control in an area can lead to demoralization, or a sense of one's lifestyle being threatened. At some point, residents or businesses may feel compelled to leave the area; thus physical displacement may stem from social rather than economic pressure. Social displacement might be marked by a gradual withdrawal from neighborhood activities by the displaced. They drop out of local organizations or remove themselves from political activities. Thus, they complete their own displacement by relinquishing attachments to the associations which were formerly the bases of their power. These reactions will be discussed below as regards Little Five Points.

The literature on residential revitalization has documented the demographic features of the new residential immigrant populations (Black, [Chapter 1](#) in [*Back to the City*], Bradley, 1977, 1978; Fichter, 1977; Gale, [Chapter 7](#) in [*Back to the City*]; Laska and Spain [Chapter 8](#) in [*Back to the City*]; Zeitz, 1976).

In addition, revitalization has sparked interest in the displacement of lower-

income groups (U.S. Senate, 1977). Typically the focus is on the physical dislocation of people and the economic impact of this dislocation with an eye toward developing mechanisms to ease the burden of higher rents and property taxes or actual physical displacement (as when a multifamily unit is converted to single-family status). Some small body of research has been concerned with the social problems associated with revitalization, rather than the physical displacement per se (cf. Cybriwsky, 1978; see also Levy and Cybriwsky, [Chapter 9](#) in [*Back to the City*]). Cybriwsky describes the resentment of the new migrants by the old and even some vandalism directed against the property of the new residents. In general, however, relatively little work to date has dealt with the social dynamics which often accompany neighborhood change.

Studies concerned with revitalizing commercial areas have dealt even less with the social than those concerned exclusively with residential areas. Loan availability, the dollar volume in the market area and the mix of goods and services (Goldstein and Davis, 1977; Lemmon, 1978) are examples of types of economic factors which have been examined. While these studies attend to the residential context of the commercial district, they do so mainly in terms of market considerations. Rarely is there mention of the social aspects of the relationship between the two. One can draw a conceptual distinction between a commercial area and its residential context, but in fact the two are typically linked. The former, by offering a particular type of goods and services, may draw a certain population to adjoining neighborhoods. Conversely, the composition of residential neighborhoods can influence the decisions of merchants and proprietors to locate in the area or to modify the nature of their merchandise, hoping to capture a portion of the proximate market. Because of the interrelationships, changes in one can lead to changes in the other.

This chapter focuses on the controversy among the neighborhood and commercial residents over a proposed redevelopment plan for Little Five Points for which \$350,000 of federal Community Development Block Grant (CDBG) funds have been allocated. A formal plan exists (City of Atlanta), calling for sidewalk repair, general beautification, and most controversially, the establishment of two small pedestrian malls achieved by an alteration of street patterns in LFP.

The exploration of social displacement in LFP begins in the mid-1960s, with changes in the surrounding residential areas, the spread of change to LFP itself, and the resultant change in the composition of the LFP business community. The dispute over the plan will be examined as it reflects the social displacement problems associated with the compositional changes. [. . .]

THE DEVELOPMENT OF COMMERCIAL CONFLICT

The first clashes among members of the LFP business district occurred in the mid-1960s over transportation. One centered on a state plan to construct two major interstate highways which would have passed close to the center of LFP, one cutting directly through Inman Park. The second involved a plan to widen Moreland Avenue, the main traffic artery through LFP. Part of this latter project was actually completed, running south from the center of LFP; the proposal was to complete the widening through the rest of LFP to the north. In general, the business community at that time was in favor of both projects, believing that they would stimulate business by bringing additional traffic into the area.

This sentiment was not shared by residents of a number of neighborhoods through which the roads were to pass. Although land acquisition and the demolition of housing units had already begun, a coalition of neighborhood groups was formed to fight the highways, an effort that

proved to be at least temporarily successful. The Moreland Avenue project likewise fell upon hard times and although not ultimately defeated, it has been halted for the time being. Both these issues represent the first confrontation between the business district and the new migrants to the surrounding residential areas.

While the business community may have been fairly well united in its support for the interstate construction and arterial widening, it did not prevail. The newer residents in surrounding neighborhoods, essentially middle-class, were a political force of growing potency. Coupled with the general awareness across the country of local neighborhood power, whether of the lower- or middle-class variety, the anti-highway victories enhanced the confidence of the neighborhood residents in their ability to affect public plans (cf. Advisory Commission on Intergovernmental Relations, 1972; Cole, 1974; Kansas City Urban Observatory, n.d.; Yin and Yates, 1974; Yin and Lucas, 1973).

The Fight over the Highways

Many members of the LFP business community recognize the controversies over Moreland Avenue and the two freeways as the root of conflict in the area which today is manifested in the dispute over the redevelopment plan to "beautify" LFP. As a plan opponent put it:

There has been conflict over several things between the business community and the housing restorers, the restoration group. It started a number of years ago when the Stone-Mountain [Interstate 485] Freeway was proposed. . . . And the business community felt it would be the greatest boon to business that had ever come through the neighborhood and the restoration group said no, it would just totally destroy everything they'd been working for. . . . That was the beginning of some conflicts and some disagreements. There have been quite a few other issues.

The conflicts over the highways and street widening are, however, more than just past battles. They continue to provide an explanation for the attitudes people hold toward the LFP redevelopment plan. The plan's proponents are especially sensitive to the situation created by the defeat of the highways. One said:

The people who have been the most adamant against the plan are people who are major property owners in the area. You go back about ten years. . . . and we were looking to have a freeway through this area and a widened Moreland Avenue and a MARTA [Metropolitan Atlanta Regional Transit Authority] station built right on top of Moreland Avenue down here. So if you were a property owner in Little Five Points, you'd been here 20, 30 years; you'd seen your property values decline and go downhill. You're older; you're thinking about your retirement or where you'd like to live. You'd like to get your money out of your property. You'd like to sell it for a good price. Well, the freeway, the widening, and all this stuff, all of a sudden you see a lot of hope. The property in the area's going to be worth something again. So first of all here come all these neighborhood people and they kill off the freeway. Then they kill off the Moreland Avenue widening. MARTA moves the rapid transit station. . . . So all of a sudden, and then, as if to add insult to injury, now they start coming and talking about closing streets in Little Five Points. It's not hard to see how from some people's point of view, all of a sudden they were going to have this great opportunity to at some point sell their property or redevelop it and do real well and from their point of view all that's been destroyed. And here it's going to be this little neighborhood shopping area where you don't have big companies interested in the land.

Looking back over the same issues, current plan opponents take the view that (1) the widening and the new freeways would have been good for business, (2) the neighborhood people are generally opposed to vehicular traffic for selfish reasons, and (3)

opposition to the roads reflects an unrealistic vision of what is necessary in the area. Moreover, several argued that the defeat of these projects involved collusion between area residents and city officials, a “conspiratorial” theory of sorts.

[Regarding the Moreland Avenue widening] some of the [City] Council people had got some information that the federal government was going to issue some Community Development funds to revitalize some of the older residential-business areas. So they smelt [sic] an opportunity to make a dollar. So they had a meeting that nobody would know anything about and the City voted to turn thumbs down on the widening. . . . Some of this group, friends of the Council group, even one or more Council persons got together and formed a corporation and bought the buildings [in LFP]. . . . They bought that because they were figuring on being able to get this money.

That a “conspiracy” theory should emerge among the minority is not remarkable in and of itself. But the emergence of this explanation of events and the defeat of the roads set the stage for an intensification of such feelings over subsequent issues. The quotation above is a rare expression of “conspiracy” related to the earlier highway issues; it is a more frequent response to the current redevelopment plan. Whereas the controversy over the Interstate and the street widening occurred between the business community and an “outside” agent (i.e., the residential communities), the present conflict illustrates the same attitudinal differences but the range of opinions is now found within the business community itself.

The “Infiltration” of Little Five Points

Although it is impossible to specify the characteristics of a “new” kind of business in LFP, as opposed to the older businesses, observers in the area generally agree that

the first “new” businesses began arriving about five years ago. Since that time, many have moved into the area, some of them only briefly. The features of the new businesses which are most pertinent to this discussion are that (1) they are often owned by area residents, often people from Candler Park, (2) the goods and services they offer are more directly aimed at the residents of surrounding neighborhoods, (3) they rely to a large extent on local residents for their business, and, most importantly, (4) they have a view of the kind of business district Little Five Points should be which contrasts with the orientation of some of the older merchants.

These new proprietors, many already active in neighborhood civic associations, began joining the Business Association a few years ago. Now they are the “majority” in LFP. This change is noteworthy because it previews the social displacement experienced by older merchants and property owners in the area. For the first time, the hegemony of the traditional business leaders was challenged. The challenge was, and is, over very real issues, represented today by the redevelopment plan for the use of CDBG funds.

I use the term “infiltration” somewhat facetiously to describe the changing composition of the business district. The new businesses are legitimate rent-paying tenants or property owners. But their arrival represents the spread to LFP and the type of individual who is moving into Inman Park and Candler Park. This development reinforces the link between the two. Whichever is the primary casual direction (the desire by new residents to reform the business area or the lure of new residents to their neighborhoods because of the business district) there is a decreasing distinction between the characteristics of the neighborhoods and those of the majority of merchants in LFP. This difference between the new and old business people will be made

clear in an examination of the dispute over the redevelopment plan.

THE CONFLICT OVER THE REDEVELOPMENT PLAN

As mentioned earlier, the redevelopment plan calls for a number of "beautification" projects in and changes in the street patterns within the business district. It is on this latter aspect of the plan that the controversy hinges. The term "street closing" has itself become something of a battle cry for the plan's opponents. Proponents, conversely, use other terms, like "traffic rerouting." Despite the apparent centering of the argument over the effects on business of the new traffic pattern, there appear to be other factors involved and other considerations in the minds of the participants.

Essentially, the conflict over the plan is the first major issue to arise within the reconstituted business district, pitting one portion of the community against another instead of against some outside entity. The framework of social displacement offers insights to the dispute that a consideration of the strictly "economic impact" facets cannot explain. The interviews reveal an awareness by participants of other dimensions. The plan has become a symbolic issue, reflective of control of power over the affairs of the local business community.

The "Conspiracy" Theory

One common thread running through the comments of the plan's opponents is the "closed" and secretive nature of the development of the plan and, indeed, the intentions of its original formulators. Opponents argue that the plan was developed by a small number of local people who had close ties to City Hall and who used those connections to their advantage in getting the plan approved. Also, they believe that the plan is intended to benefit a small number of

business people in LFP, people who established businesses there for the express purpose of taking advantage of the grant money. The conduct of this new group during the development of the plan was believed to be generally secretive and deliberately exclusionary of the older business people. As one of the long-time owners says: "The owners of the [business] and the [business] . . . have some silent partners that have ties to City Hall. Well, I think that some of the people that have stock in those two corporations either work for or hold elected positions in the City of Atlanta." Another, referring to a neighborhood meeting to discuss and vote on the plan: "I hadn't planned to go because I didn't know they were going to have it. That was always the way. Everything was already done and we were not told; we were not supposed to know. They didn't want us to know about it."

Characterization of "the Others"

Along with the lack of trust between the groups over the origin and intent of the plan is a questioning of the character of the "opposition." Some of this uneasiness results from age differences (original business people are older in years than the newer) and the accompanying lifestyle and sociopolitical differences. Older merchants apply such terms as "hippie type" and "radical" to some of the newer proprietors and newer residents in surrounding areas. Beyond this, though, is a tendency to question the legitimacy of some of the newer businesses. Here is a representative statement from an opponent of the plan:

I don't approve of the type businesses we're getting in here that, to me, have no really visible means of support. And it makes me suspicious really as to how the businesses are being supported. . . . Where's the money coming from? Is somebody else supplying it? Or . . . have we got a marijuana operation on the side

at certain hours? The money has to be coming from someplace and it don't come from the business that walks in the place and buys the merchandise. . . . They're being subsidized or there's something that's not legitimate.

Conversely, plan proponents portray some of the older merchants as "being afraid of change." The older businesses are seen as unwilling or unable to change to take advantage of the new character of the residential neighborhoods. They are carrying goods not desired by those new residents and staying with marketing and display practices that put them at a competitive disadvantage. Plan proponents seem to believe that there is money enough to be made by everyone if only the older business people will face up to the changes which have taken place in the neighborhoods and make the necessary alterations.

These remarks of the plan's friends and foes speak to the replacement of one group by another in the general area which encompasses both the residential and business communities. The proponents of the plan insist that no damage has been done to the older businesses save what they brought upon themselves by not being "smart" in their operations. The opponents of the plan make more personal their attack upon the individuals and business which now form the majority in an area which was once "theirs."

The Prerogatives of Tenure

In the remarks made by some plan opponents concerning the manner in which the plan was developed and "pushed" through the approval process, there is an attitude of having been excluded from that process, even deliberately. In the past, a more homogeneous business community may well have operated in a more informal manner. People were well acquainted with one another, with ties extending back over the

years. These older business people are, after all, people who in the past were dominant in the community and who played a major role in any issue or decision facing LFP. Now, numerically if in no other way, they have been supplanted by individuals they do not know personally. The loss of hegemony, in the Business Association and in community affairs in general, is a critical aspect of the social displacement argument. Several plan proponents seemed sensitive to this issue:

I think there was a kind of proprietorship, sense of proprietorship, of Little Five Points that maybe it's expected that people would come to them as the people who had been here and ask their advice and ask them what they wanted, and they would be in control.

They at one time ran the Association, were the Association, and usually had a say. Now they are the minority, and they feel that they have probably been pushed out. And they resent this.

. . . some people who've been here a very long time, and I'm sure naturally feel they have some prerogative by virtue of how long they've been here. Then me and other people come marching in here with their own ideas of how it ought to be, join the Business Association, and work to support this revitalization plan.

In a straightforward sense, the older business people in LFP have lost their dominant position in the community. It is possible to document the change through the office holding in the Business Association and by votes on community issues. A strictly political transformation has taken place; barring some major reversal, the organizational control of LFP lies in the hands of the newer business people.

Different Visions of the Future

Social displacement is seen not only in the control of the Business Association and the sense of exclusion during the plan development sequence. A different view of

the business district has developed among the newer businesses. Or, at least, this “philosophy” is seen by the participants as being distinct. The plan’s proponents stress their commitment to a community-oriented, community-controlled business district. They want a strong pedestrian environment as opposed to an automobile oriented “strip.” This manifests itself over the Moreland Avenue widening issue. Plan proponents believe older businesses view LFP as a work place only, and their interests in the area are seen to be purely business. Plan opponents, who recognize the plan as an attempt to create this localized, pedestrian shopping center, believe that this thrust is not in the ultimate best interests of business in LFP. The proponents are seen as “illogical” or “dreamers.” Moreover they are seen as talking out of both sides of their mouths. On the one hand, say the opponents, they talk “community,” but in fact they are interested in making money from the redevelopment plan, and the desire for this profit is what lies behind the formulation of the plan in the first place: “I think that the groups that is [sic] controlling the plan are the ones that expect to benefit from it from a financial standpoint.” In contrast to the above, the proponents state:

I think it has a lot to do with the residential thing, to get back to that—I think it comes down more to community. There are people who feel that this is my community. . . . This is typically of the point of view of people I call new businesses. The old businesses, they don’t see it that way. It’s a place where they work. Their commitment ends more or less with that.

They don’t live here. They don’t have real commitment to this area other than it’s where they own a business or own some property. And maybe they were interested in selling off their property or selling off their businesses and moving their business out to where they live. Most of the people that I know that are involved in [business] or any other business

in this neighborhood . . . live here or nearby. It’s not just a place where they work. It’s the center of their community.

These distinctions point to the changing dominant philosophy governing decisions affecting LFP. Or at least they indicate a perception of such a difference. And the perception is the more important factor to the people involved.

OBSERVATIONS ON SOCIAL DISPLACEMENT

Social displacement seems to be a good term to describe the process taking place in Little Five Points, wherein one group of individuals is gaining a dominant position at the expense of another. The history of the area in the past 15 years shows, first, a transition in the residential neighborhoods around LFP that evidenced itself in the successful battle against the interstate projects and against the position of the business community. Over time, the effect of the residential transition filtered into the business district directly as the neighborhoods provided a base from which small businesses arose and drew their support. Currently, there is a confrontation between the “old” and “new” interests in LFP over the redevelopment plan.

The plan itself is crucial in highlighting the division which has developed in LFP and in bringing into the open the attitudes and opinions of members of the business community. It is catalytic in its effect. The process of social displacement which has been going on for ten years might have led to a similar division over any such issue. So in some respects, the division over the plan was inevitable; it reflects the changing composition of the residential and business communities. This change, involving people with different characteristics and different viewpoints, has led simultaneously to a transformation in the way the business

community views itself, its purpose, and its relationship to the residential neighborhoods.

It is difficult to say whether LFP is more polarized today than a decade ago. Certainly the lack of communication between the two groups contributes to stereotypical thinking. The stereotyping evidences itself in the retrospective construction of reality, wherein past issues, like the highway, are likely to be interpreted in terms of the current division. Moreover, it can be seen in the expectations of the positions individuals will take on upcoming issues, such as the use of the vacant highway right-of-way. These processes play upon one another. Thus, perhaps the reason “conspiracy” is not seen as dominant for the highway conflict is that older-term business people viewed it as an isolated situation. But when the redevelopment plan is added to the picture, the “whole thing is put in perspective.”

Policy Implications

Despite the seemingly necessary confrontation, a confrontation found in other studies (Cybriwsky, 1978; see also [Chapter 9](#) in this volume), there are, I believe, steps which could have minimized the severity of the cleavage and “softened” the blow associated with social displacement. The new business people, schooled in neighborhood associations and neighborhood battles, were familiar with the tactics required to manage an issue. They were accustomed to the mechanism of public meetings and the necessity of making sure that one’s side is adequately represented at such meetings. Older business people, in fact, make frequent use of the term “packing” to describe the recruitment of support for the plan at public meetings. And they seem aware of the general feeling that they are at a disadvantage in dealing with the government: “I do think that they have advantages that the older taxpayers have paid for and now, as a

result of their being better educated, and in the know about all this stuff, it’s being used against us.”

One obvious response is that governmental agencies sponsoring plans or projects for changing areas, either residential or commercial, should show a higher level of sensitivity for the older participants and should work harder to make sure they are made aware of and given full opportunity to participate in the development of such projects. The older business people in Little Five Points complain that they were never advised of the redevelopment plan or that they learned about it only after it had been significantly developed. This may well be the case even though announcements of meetings are a matter of public record. But these members of the community may be more accustomed to discussing matters informally with information being passed by word of mouth. They had not been participants in the rise of “community power” and suffered for lack of that participation.

Sensitivity to this problem would not, of course, change the overall course of events in communities like Little Five Points. But it could perhaps reduce the destructiveness of bad relationships in a commercial area which is struggling to revive itself and which can only be hurt by an internal division. Inner-city shopping areas have too many problems to contend with to be able to tolerate “family feuds.” In LFP, there is little in the way of personal antagonism except in a few isolated cases. But the general level of mistrust and the absence of communication help explain why the community has found it difficult to reach a compromise on the plan.

The emergence of a common enemy could reunite this area, but it is hardly a development which can be planned or upon which one should base one’s hopes. Without assigning blame for the current breakdown in communication, various

participants, including the newer merchants and the city itself, could have acted in ways which would have reduced the level of tension. The older business people have a stake in the area and as members of the community should not be overlooked.

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